Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

6

Refugee Postmemories: The "Generation After"

I began searching for a history, my own history, because I had known all along that the stories I had heard were not true and parts had been left out. I remember having this feeling growing up that I was haunted by something, that I was living within a family full of ghosts. There was this place that they knew about. I had never been there. We had been moved, uprooted. We had lived with a lot of pain. I had no idea where these memories came from, yet I knew the place.

From Rea Tajiri's film, *History and Memory*

One day, in a class on U.S. wars in Asia, I lectured on the spraying of chemical defoliation on Vietnamese soil by the U.S. military during the Vietnam War, which killed or maimed an estimated 400,000 people and poisoned the country's water, land, and air. That night, a young Vietnamese student in the class dreamed that her body was covered with the toxic Agent Orange. Like many U.S.-born Vietnamese Americans of her generation, she knew little about the details of the war prior to taking the class. Yet, in her nightmare, her body somehow "recalled" the physical pain endured by older generations of Vietnamese during the war. This chapter analyzes the experiences of the post-1975 generation: the young Vietnamese who were born in Vietnam or in the United States after the official end of the Vietnam War. How do young Vietnamese Americans, born and/or raised in the United States, create "memories" of a war that preceded their births or their consciousness? How are these memories mediated by their parents' direct experiences with and recollections of the war, by the politics of war commemoration practiced in the home, and by both Vietnam and the United States?

This book, and this chapter in particular, arises from a set of concerns that revolve around silences and silencing and their relation to structures of power. In the previous chapters, I have discussed the silence of history, both in the United States and in Vietnam, on the ongoing costs of the war borne by the South Vietnamese. In this chapter, I am interested in the silences that prevail within refugee families and that arbitrate interpersonal relations, paying particular attention to their capacity to index structures of power, violence, and identity.[1] Over the past few decades, feminist scholars have shown that war is not exclusively a matter for men, or a masculine domain. Instead, it is a complex process that transforms not only public institutions and national economies but also intimate relationships.[2] Adopting this feminist approach, I pay particular attention to what British cultural materialist Raymond Williams terms the "structure of feeling": social experiences that are often not "recognized as social but taken to be private, idiosyncratic, and even isolating."[3] As such, feelings, though "actively lived and felt," are "elusive, impalpable forms of social consciousness" and thus tend to disappear from social analysis altogether.[4] Since the most common modes of social analysis define the social as the known and reduce it to fixed forms, they tend to miss the "complexities, the experienced tensions, shifts, and uncertainties, the intricate forms of unevenness and confusion" that constitute the living present.[5] However, Williams argues that the alternative to these

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

analytical reductions is not the silencing or disappearance of these complexities and tensions but "a kind of feeling and thinking which is indeed social and material."[6]

The process of generational transmission of war memory is complex and difficult, not only for the survivors but also for their children, as the latter move between honoring their elders' memory and constructing their own relation to this contentious legacy.[7] In a lucid account of the intergenerational legacy of the Holocaust, Marianne Hirsch argues that shards of memories of traumatic events persist to mark the lives of children of survivors. Although separated in time and space from the devastating histories, the postwar generation "remembers" these powerful experiences by means of the fractured images, stories, behaviors, and affects transmitted, sometimes indirectly and wordlessly, within the family and the culture at large.[8] Hirsch has called this memory of the "generation after" *postmemory*: "the experience of being separated in time and space from the war being remembered, yet of living with the eyewitness memory."[9] According to Hirsch, postmemory—a secondary, mediated, and inherited memory of a lost past—is not the same as memory in that it does not recall but rather imagines, projects, and creates the past, yet it can be just as weighty because it "approximates memory in its affective force."[10]

As discussed in chapter 5, Vietnam, both the war and the country, continues to be a site of contradictions and ambivalence for the first generation. How are these layered memories, which contain both "nostalgic longing as well as negative critical recollection," transmitted to and understood by the postwar generation?[11] How has this "grip of the bequeathed trauma" manifested, not only psychically but also materially, in the lives of young Vietnamese Americans?[12] Although this grip is powerful, it is difficult to say precisely what it is or what it does. As I detail below, the war appears to have no consistent meaning for young Vietnamese Americans; rather, it is a shifting specter that hovers over personal heartaches, family tensions and dissolution, and/or economic insecurities.

The information in this chapter comes primarily from in-depth tape-recorded interviews that my then-research assistant, Thúy Võ Đặng, and I conducted with sixty Vietnamese Americans—thirty men and thirty women—in Southern California between 2005 and 2010.[13] All of the respondents belong to the postwar generation: the majority (57 percent) were born between 1981 and 1985; 26 percent between 1975 and 1980; and 17 percent between 1986 and 1990. Over half of the respondents (55 percent) were born in Vietnam; 38 percent in the United States; and 7 percent in a refugee camp. In-depth interviews are valuable because they allow us to listen to individuals' own interpretations, definitions, and perceptions of their experiences. As Irving Seidman suggests, "At the root of in-depth interviewing is an interest in understanding the lived experience of other people and the meaning they make of that experience . . . because [their stories] are of worth."[14] Yet we now know that interview data, especially about a topic as fraught as that of war memories, are full of gaps. It is true that people lie or evade, but it is also the case that, by their very nature, war-related stories contain many uncertainties and projections. As Grace Cho insists in her work on Korean trauma memories, the point is not to smooth over or fill in the gaps but "to enter these empty spaces to find out what emerges, what one can learn from listening to silence." Like Cho, I believe that the interweaving threads that cover up the traumas of war "are not so tightly woven that [they] cannot come undone."[15] Thus, in what follows, my aim is not to cross-check the oral stories against documented histories but rather to point out the suggestive and productive nature of the gaps, cracks, and uncertainties that are part and parcel of the (re)tellings of Vietnamese lives.

"THEY CERTAINLY DON'T TEACH IT IN SCHOOL!"

Writing on the postmemory of the children of Holocaust survivors, Hirsch contends that even "the most intimate familial knowledge of the past is *mediated* by broadly available public images and narratives."[16] However, whereas the descendants of Holocaust refugees have access to the multitude of Holocaust memorials, both material and cultural, and live within an American public history and a culture that acknowledges, commemorates, and mourns their losses, Vietnamese refugee children have to come to terms

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

with their family histories of war, loss, and displacement amid the representational emptiness and the deliberate concealment of the war's costs borne by their parents' generation.[17] For the most part, all that the children of Vietnam War refugees have is a "wayward archive, a grasping at the ineffable, a dialogue with ghosts."[18] Amid this organized forgetting, how do young Vietnamese acquire, sustain, erase, and/or transform *their* understanding of the Vietnam War?

For young Vietnamese Americans, the continuing U.S. ambivalence about the Vietnam War means that their relationship with American history and their ability to claim a Vietnamese American identity is tenuous at best. In particular, the absence of Vietnamese perspective(s) of the war in public education has affected Vietnamese youths' identity and well-being. A Southern California task force—formed in the late 1990s to investigate troubling patterns of gang membership, school drop-outs, relatively high rates of suicide, and intergenerational conflicts among Southeast Asian youth—concluded that "the sense of not belonging and not knowing their roots intensified the identity crisis that normal adolescents experience."[19] As an example, a Vietnamese American high school student told a task force interviewer that his involvement in gang activities stemmed from "this emptiness and void" that he longed to fill: "What good is it to earn straight A's and receiving all these accolades when you don't know who you are?"[20] Another frustrated student ranted about the lack of access to Vietnamese history and culture, both at home and in school:

> I grew up in a low-income neighborhood. I was never a whiz, never a valedictorian. I was constantly criticized. Vietnamese youth are constantly criticized by elders. They say we don't know, don't understand, our history and culture. But where do we go to learn this? They don't talk about it at home and they certainly don't teach it in school![21]

Given the lack of meaningful Vietnam War curricula in U.S. schools, especially ones that incorporate Vietnamese history, culture, and experience, it is not surprising that many of the U.S.-born Vietnamese we interviewed possessed incomplete knowledge of the war. Embarrassed and apologetic, these young people insisted that, as Vietnamese, they should have known more—somehow. In the excerpt below, Mimi Lâm,[22] who was born in the United States and raised by a single mother, was clearly flustered when she could not provide a coherent synopsis of the war:

> Urgh! I sound so stupid. I don't think I learned about the Vietnam War anywhere, even in college. Besides the few movies I've watched. I took two Asian Pacific American studies classes [in college] and we didn't talk about the Vietnam War. I think I even read the books thoroughly but there just wasn't anything. The war was in the seventies, right? So why were they fighting? I honestly don't know why. Something about the Communists, I don't know. I know the Việt Cô.ng tried to fight because they wanted Communism and the U.S. didn't want Communism. I'm really bad . . . I'm horrible. . . . I feel dumb. I just don't know much about it. I'm sorry!

Mimi's butchering of even the most basic facts of the war is not typical. The majority of the U.S.-born Vietnamese we interviewed were able to name some of the war's key timelines, concepts, and events—information that they had gathered, often in snatches, from high school or college history courses. But what they uniformly lacked, and wanted, was a coherent framework that explains the whys of the war from a Vietnamese standpoint. Minh Nguyễn, whose family came to the United States via a perilous boat journey and prolonged stays in two refugee camps, expressed this ambivalence when he said, "We were taught that the war was America's first mistake and they shouldn't have gone in there to help the people. And a lot of people died. . . . But then it seems like America did help, since the Vietnamese people are now in America. But I really don't know. . . . I don't know how to view the war. . . . I just want to know how to feel about things."

In many ways, Vietnamese American ambivalence about the Vietnam War mirrors that of the larger American society. As discussed earlier, the United States has solidified the master narratives of World War II around the myth of American benevolence and racial democracy, but it has still not been able to resolve the conflicting memories of the Vietnam War—a war that deeply divided the country and called into question its national image and international reputation. As a visible reminder of the war, Vietnamese in the United States have had to bear the brunt of these irresolutions. Ngọc Liên Nguyễn recounted that her mother, who

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

came to the United States at the age of twenty-three in 1977, faced the hostility of a country still reeling from the recent loss in Vietnam, which affected her job prospects: "She came here to California. She tried to get a job and she got turned down because she didn't know how to speak English yet. But she said that a lot of the people that she went to for jobs looked at her like she was part of the problem, like she was the cause of the whole war. That's what she interpreted it as. She said that her last name is Nguyễn, so people knew that she was Vietnamese." As a consequence, some young Vietnamese Americans avoided the topic of the war altogether for fear that they would be mistaken for America's war enemies rather than its allies. As Hùng Pha. m, who came to the United States in 1979 at the age of two, explained:

> It's kind of sad that I know nothing about the war, but in school, I would kind of feel a little awkward when they would talk about the Vietnam War. So maybe for some reason I blocked it out of my head because of that, just because . . . obviously I'm from *there.* For the longest time, when I was growing up, I kind of felt like the white people didn't really like us too much because maybe the families they lost or whatever . . . because of the war.

Ngọc Châu Hồ, who was just two months old when her extended family of eighteen set out on what would become a two-year journey to the United States, concurred: "I think it's still a very touchy subject. In my high school, no one really knew how to teach it or talk about it. I didn't want to talk about it either. I didn't want to say that my family is Vietnamese and have to deal with all of that and all the questions that I couldn't answer." Tina Ngọc Đặng, a twenty-two-year-old college student at the time of the interview, did have "to deal with all of that" the summer she graduated from high school, when she was aboard a tour bus heading to the Vietnam Veterans Memorial in Washington, D. C. Already feeling vulnerable in such a setting, Tina was startled when an older white man paused in front of her and spit out, "My brother died in your jungle," before proceeding to the back of the bus. Shaken, Tina got off at the next stop and never made it to the memorial. These incidents of racial lumping shape young Vietnamese Americans' postmemory of the Vietnam War, instructing them that their place in the United States is intimately, and at times violently, related to Americans' racialized understanding of "Vietnam" and its people.

Vietnamese media, especially the wildly popular Vietnamese musical variety series *Paris By Night,* fill in some of the missing history for young Vietnamese Americans. Since 1983, the Thúy Nga Production Company has produced and distributed over a hundred *Paris By Night* episodes that feature Vietnamese-language musical performances, one-act plays, and comedy skits. With a huge and loyal following, *Paris By Night* has become a leading cultural and political voice of and for the Vietnamese diaspora—a ubiquitous presence in Vietnamese homes and Vietnamese-run businesses such as restaurants and nail and hair salons.[23] *Paris By Night 77* was the episode that my interviewees referenced the most: produced in 2005, it commemorated the thirtieth anniversary of the Fall of Saigon. The show interspersed three prominent themes: the cruelty and corruption of communist rule, the flight and plight of Vietnamese refugees, and the progress of Vietnamese communities in the United States. Most compelling for my interviewees were the montages of frantic Vietnamese fleeing Saigon, perishing at sea, and languishing in overcrowded refugee camps. Twenty-year-old Lisa Vũ, a third-year college student majoring in political science, explained how *Paris By Night 77* helped her to "create" memories of the war: "The images that I have [of the war] are created from *Paris By Night*: the mother holding her children and running . . . bombings . . . jungle warfare. I have this image of a family just running in the dark. It's always at night. Oh, and the raidings and people hiding from the Communists so that they don't get shot."

Many of the young Vietnamese whom I interviewed, like Hắng Võ, connected viscerally to the searing images of anguished Vietnamese on their screen:

> It's just so emotional for me to watch what happened during the war and postwar and how people died. Even though I can't relate to what my parents went though, I can feel it through those videos and have an idea of how difficult it was. I don't know why it's so emotional, but whenever I watch, it always brings tears to my eyes. . . . Just seeing people running for their lives and running to try to get to the U.S. makes me imagine that those people are my parents and that was what they went through. All of my aunts that came over here were boat people. I see how the boat people go through all of that and I would think, oh my gosh, that's what they went through. When I watch *Paris By Night* or *Asia* [another musical variety series] and when it gets to that part, I can't watch and I just walk away because I get so emotional that I can't sit

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

there without crying.

For these young viewers, the emotional quality of the *Paris By Night* thirtieth anniversary show contrasted sharply with the objectification of Vietnamese often found in American media. As twenty-two-year-old Hân Trần, a psychology student, explained:

> I think from the American media, it's a war that the U.S. lost. The U.S. came in as the heroes, helping these poor and ignorant Vietnamese people. We are always shown as peasants or hookers. So we were objects. From the Vietnamese perspective, there has much more emotion attached. This is the war that *we* lost. We fought and we fought but we still lost. It's more personal I think, hearing and seeing the Vietnamese perspective. The 30-year anniversary show was very moving. It was from the Vietnamese perspective and it allowed me to see the whole perspective.

On occasion, these Vietnamese-language media act as a prop and a prompt for parents to begin disclosing their war experiences. As Hân elaborated, "One thing that would bring up communism and the war would be when we watch *Paris By Night.* They would sometimes have shows on the war. That's probably the only time when I would hear [my parents] talk about it. They would watch it and sometimes casually mention something that they could relate to or something that they don't agree with." For some parents, no shows could ever capture the reality of war as they experienced it. As Lisa Vũ recounted, "We saw the *Paris By Night* video when they commemorated the 30 years, and my stepfather was like, they should have shown more footage of the war and this and that. He's never happy with those things. They are never warlike enough for him and it's never real enough for him. That's because it's still so real in his mind."

THE SOUNDS OF SILENCE: "THEY DON'T WANT TO TALK ABOUT IT"

As complex and subtle as spoken language, silence, as a language of family, can protect and cherish and/or deny and control.[24] Writing on the cross-generational transmission of historical trauma, scholars have noted that, in many families, silence prevails and that children of survivors experience family history as one of "untold stories."[25] In her important film *History and Memory,* third-generation Japanese American filmmaker Rea Tajiri discloses that she was haunted by her parents' silence about their internment camp experience: "I was living within a family full of ghosts."[26] In the same way, Vietnamese refugee families wrap their war memories in a shroud of silence and forgetting. When asked to recount what their parents had told them about their war experiences, the respondents' most common answer was: "They don't want to talk about it." Nancy Thúy Trần, whose parents came to the United States in 1976 as boat people, exclaimed that "they tell me straight up that they don't want to tell me." Even when she needed the details for a homework assignment, her parents were still hesitant: "They don't want to have like a full-on discussion. Growing up, I have heard of the war . . . like I keep hearing about an older brother [of my dad] who passed away, and my grandma would mention him and his name. But I only got just bits and pieces of it." Jennifer Lê's parents also deflected her questions about their past: "My dad especially never talked about his personal experiences with the war. It was always like, 'Oh yeah, I went to America,' but he never really said why. . . . I was thinking that the war had a role to play in it, but I don't really know what."

Ruth Wajnryb has written eloquently about the difficulty of transmitting knowledge about trauma across generations: "From the parents' perspective, the dilemma was how to tell what they could not bear their children to have to hear."[27] In the case of Holocaust survivors, Anna Neumann reports that "protected stories," sanitized and marked by silences, are often told to children in bits and pieces, in an effort to *protect* them from the brutal realities of the Holocaust.[28] Yet, as Eva Hoffman reminds us, within the space of the family, survivors *speak* even when they utter no words: "The past broke through in the sounds of nightmares, the idioms of signs and illness, of tears and acute aches."[29] For the young people we interviewed, the occasional and often caught-unawares moments when "the past broke through" and interrupted their parents' silence were unnerving. Nancy Thúy Trần remembered feeling panicky when her father started crying in the middle of a war movie: "I remember thinking, 'Don't panic!' The war was a hush-hush thing; I just didn't

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

want to cause any more grief." Others recalled how war terrors haunted their parents' sleep in the form of recurring "screaming and yelling" nightmares about exploding bombs, gnawing hunger, capsized boats, and dead bodies. For the children of survivors and witnesses of the Vietnam War, these episodes confirm that the war is ever-present for their parents, whether they speak about it or not. In Dũng Vũ's words: "It's in their minds, it's in their sleep, and it's there in their memories."

The silence that pervades familial interactions emanates not only from the first generation but also from their children—the generation after. In her research on Japanese Canadian women's internment memories, Mona Oikawa learned that daughters take "great care" when they initiate conversations regarding the internment with their mothers, lest these discussions dredge up best-forgotten memories. As Oikawa writes, "Just as parents develop strategies to cope with the memories they live with, children also develop strategies for living with the memories shared and not shared in their own families."[30] Wajnryb concurs: "From the child's perspective, it was how to hear what they could not bear their parents to have to tell."[31] Over and over, the young Vietnamese Americans we interviewed indicated that not probing about the past was their way of protecting their parents from having to relive the terrors of wartime and its immediate aftermath. Vinh Dương, whose parents suffered greatly during the twelve-year period that his father was imprisoned in a reeducation camp, struggled with the weight of his family history:

> My parents don't talk about their history much mostly because it consists of suffering . . . and even when they do talk about it and stuff, sometimes I do try to block that out because it's so sad. . . . It's not that I'm trying to deny it, it's just that . . . I just lose hope sometimes when I hear about how my mom has suffered and all of the hardships that she went through. . . . With my dad, I asked him, "Why don't you ever talk about your time in war?" And he was like, "What is there to talk about?" And that would end the conversation. Umm, I didn't want to push it because there might be some unfortunate memories that he has that he doesn't want to share, like I don't want to open old wounds or anything like that but I was so curious.

Phượng Lê also hesitated to prod her father about the details of his seven years in a reeducation camp. Although her father, whom she did not formally meet until his arrival in the United States in 1991 when she was already eight years old, would provide general information about reeducation camps, he refused to divulge details about his own experiences:

> I know the general stories that many people know, which was that it was horrible. In the reeducation camp, you don't have enough food and they put you in a small room so that you don't have room to move. You eat a feast if you had a cockroach. You don't even have grass to eat. The stories are really terrible but they're generic. But I don't really know the specific stories about what *he* went through. He was some sort of officer but he just didn't give me that much detail. Maybe it was so traumatizing that he just wants to ignore it. I didn't want to ask him because I was afraid that I'd bring back memories that he's trying to hide or forget.

These recollections suggest that, for many children of Vietnamese refugees, their silence is an implicit, and oftentimes complicit, attempt at family connectedness or at least family peace.[32] In this way, both the first and the second generations use silence, sometimes to control and hide but other times to love and protect—an attempt to shield family members from the painful grip of the past.[33]

HISTORY LESSONS

Many young Vietnamese Americans we interviewed expressed that they "just want[ed] to know how to feel about things," especially how to comprehend U.S. involvement in the Vietnam War: its role, motives, and tactics. Frustrated by the lack of a Vietnamese perspective on this issue, many questioned the objectivity of American sources that tout U.S. involvement in Vietnam as an effort to "save the country," "spread democracy," "stop Communism," and "help the people." As U.S.-born Vivian Thái expressed: "What I know is what I just learned or what I can remember in history class, which I think is obviously biased. It's not the opinion of the Vietnamese, but the opinion of the Americans. . . . They are always saying how America is the

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

best and how they went over there and were generous and helped out so they were good. So then, are they saying that . . . the Vietnamese and the Viet Cong were the bad guys?" Some, like Thúy Lê, questioned Americans' ability to differentiate between Vietnamese "enemies" and "allies": "What I am confused about is how do Americans know if someone is from up North or in the South or something. . . . How can the Americans come and know the difference between people they are saving and not?"

As discussed in chapter 5, the first generation's war memory, when it is shared, takes two prominent forms: critique of U.S. conduct in South Vietnam, and denunciation of communist atrocities. Many of the interviewees reported that, even when their parents remained silent on most war matters, in the privacy of their homes they would occasionally impart "history lessons" about what they perceived to be U.S. "arrogance," "incompetence," and "self-interested" conduct in the Vietnam War. This practice suggests that there is no incongruity between the refugees' expressed gratitude for their new lives in the United States and their indictment of U.S. failed military efforts. Consider the following two examples:

> So my dad and I were discussing [the war] because I was studying for AP U.S. History. I asked him if the reason why the Americans stopped helping was because of the loss of support back at home. He said that the Americans didn't know what they were doing. The war was between the North and the South, and they fought in the form of guerilla warfare. The Americans didn't know the land and they didn't know what they were doing in general. My dad said that the Americans didn't study the land hard enough. Both sides had different tactics. Compared to the Vietnamese, the Americans were much more advanced. He said that the way the Americans approached the war was very poor. He said that he felt they came in with a superior outlook like they knew they could defeat these Vietnamese people. He said that a lot of innocent people died. The Americans just killed people from both sides. They didn't care who was on whose side, so as long as they were killing someone, it was good enough. The Americans didn't have a system or a strategy for attacking at all. My dad would say things like how the U.S. were really the ones bringing the war to us and they weren't really interested in giving us our freedom.
>
> twenty-one-year-old Hưng Dương

> So war happened and the Americans decided that they were going to try and spread democracy, which I think is crap. Basically, from my stepfather's perspective and from the perspective of a lot of Vietnamese people who fought in the war, if the Americans had just helped us by giving us weapons and training us instead of trying to control the war itself, we would have won. I hear that from a lot of people in my family and from my stepfather's buddies. If it had just been a simple war, we would have won. So because outsiders got involved, it got more complicated than it should have been. From my family's perspective, the American role was to screw things up. My mom said that we were just a pawn in international politics.
>
> nineteen-year-old Timmy Trần

But when Timmy vocalized these critiques of U.S. military efforts in a classroom setting, he was immediately rebuffed:

> When I first learned about Vietnam in junior high, I got sent to the principal's office for talking back to the teacher. I think I told him that my mom told me something different, like the Americans weren't our savior or something like that, and he just got really mad. Looking back, he was in the American armed forces so that was the story that he heard. Here I am, coming in with a different perspective for the first time, probably shocked him. I remember him yelling at me, "I lost my thumb in the war. How can you say that? Go to the principal's office!" I think I got that anger about the American involvement in the war from my family, so I never cared to learn about it, and I still don't.

The teacher's (over)reaction to Timmy's version of the war exemplifies the American obsession with the Vietnam War as an *American* tragedy, and the corresponding U.S. failure to recognize that the war has its own integrity that is internal to the history and politics of Vietnam—as articulated by the parents' critiques quoted above. I am interested here less in the validity or even frequency of these critiques and more in how they enable the first generation, whose war deeds have been repeatedly dismissed or maligned, to explain or explain away their exiled, and oft-times meager, existence in the United States.

In lieu of concrete answers, some young Vietnamese Americans have latched onto the first-generation's intense emotions to anchor their own tenuous relationship to the war and its aftermath. Consider Việt Dương's moving response below:

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

> I never sympathized with the [Vietnamese] veterans before because I thought they were just stubborn people who couldn't let things go. But in 2005, when I went to April 30th [the anniversary commemoration], it was very traumatic for me. At that point, I realized that even after 30 years, they were still hanging on to it. People were crying over their sons, other veterans, brothers, people around them. I began to empathize with them. I realized that they still can't let something go. I started to understand them more. I used to think why didn't they stay there and fight then? Why did they come to America and parade around to fight Vietnamese communism because in America, no one really cares. But then I realized that they lost a lot and they were traumatized by the war. I didn't really sympathize with them until this year when I saw that man cry and people still pursuing these rights for Vietnam.

When asked if he would attend anticommunist protests in the future, he replied:

> I would, not because I think it's going to change anything that's happening in Vietnam. But it's more a statement of defiance. A lot of those people are older and so I wonder what's going to happen once they get even older and they're gone. Are we going to keep the memory of Vietnam, the war, the people who have died, and the people who are living here, alive? My interpretation of it is that the older people want to keep all the memories alive, basically to let the world know that those things did happen and we can't forget about it. . . . That would be an important message to all different people—to remind them of the war and to tell them that it did happen and that there are still people who are affected by it.

Việt's passionate but reasoned response counters the popularized image of the "fanatical" anticommunist protestor. It also calls attention to the range of possible motives for participating in anticommunist protests. In Việt's case, these protests are about the making of public history—a strident reminder to all passerbys that the war "did happen and that there are still people who are affected by it."

However, many interviewees did not share the first generation's idealization of a pre–Communist Vietnam that no longer exists. At the time of the interviews, which began in 2005, Vietnam boasted a flourishing economy and deepening ties with the United States, and thus it did not resemble the rogue state demonized by the first generation. Hương Lâm's comment is typical: "Older Vietnamese Americans are so occupied with the war that they don't even realize that there are people living in Vietnam and have lives there. It's not like Vietnam ended and there isn't anything else that is going on now." Some young people felt frustrated that their parents' generation would expend so much effort on what they perceived to be the futile enterprise "of going back to Vietnam, kicking out the Communists, and taking back the country." While the virulent anticommunist protests convey the first generation's charged emotions, they leave many questions unanswered. As U.S.-born Hiền Lâm asked: "All the homeland politics makes me wonder why I would want to be so anti-Communist and what about the Communism am I against? Is it because my family came over here and we had to leave everything behind, so are we mad about that? Or are we mad about the fact that human rights are being violated? Or are we mad about how people are not getting educated properly, and how they don't have enough to eat? What and why exactly are we anti-Communist?"

The 1.5 generation who migrated to the United States in the 1990s as part of the Orderly Departure Program[34] were especially disheartened by the hostility directed against contemporary Vietnam. Ha.nh Pha. m, who came to the United States in 1995 at the age of fourteen, considered it a "personal attack" when Vietnamese Americans denigrate the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and its people:

> I'm thinking about the group that came here in 1975 and soon after. These are the people who have never been back to Vietnam. . . . When I hear those people talk about the people in Vietnam now, it sounds like they think that those people are not as good. Because of the Communist influence, they are no longer good Vietnamese people. They are talking about Vietnam in a way that says whatever happened before 1975 is good and whatever happened after 1975 is bad. I'm part of the after, so I take it as an attack on me, when the old Vietnam is romanticized. I have seen the changes and evolution, so I feel like being stuck in that one period is not really helping us to understand who we are.

Hùng Hồ, another 1.5 generation, whose family still lives in Vietnam, also charged that "if you consider everything that is there now to be Communist, then you consider my family to be Communist. If you hate Communism, then you hate my family and if you hate my family, then you hate me. So I can't identify with that." These narratives call attention to the increasing intergenerational and political diversity that defines

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

the contemporary Vietnamese American community—a marked contrast to the one-note anticommunist stories that often appear in national media.

"DANGEROUS STORIES": FAMILY SECRETS AND TRANSGRESSIONS

Sometimes, parents remain silent because their war years involved personal transgressions best left untold since the telling would wound loved ones. In an achingly beautiful chapter on war-related family secrets, Thuy Vo Dang recounts the painful moment when, on a trip back to Vietnam, she inadvertently learned about her father's "other family." Though deeply troubling, this startling news helped explain her father's reticence about his war experiences: "My father could not talk to us too much about the war, lest these dangerous stories accidentally spill from his liquored lips." The "dangerous stories" and the father's war duties were entangled, as the "other woman" was the one who cared for him when he was injured and hospitalized in Saigon. This entanglement meant that to hide one, he had to hide the other; thus he had to assiduously "avoid the topic of his service in the army and all that he must have witnessed, endured, experienced during the war."[35] In another example, Trí Nguyễn related that his mother had a brief but passionate affair with a wealthy married man immediately before and after the Fall of Saigon—an affair made possible in part due to the chaos of wartime. Because she steadfastly refuses to discuss the affair, she shares no details about this crucial period of her life, including her feelings about the Fall of Saigon and leaving the country. One can imagine her conflicting emotions at the time: the sadness of losing a country mixed uncomfortably with the sweetness of an illicit relationship. As a result, there is a lot about the war that her son cannot glean from his mother: "I know that's a big piece of her life during the war, but she doesn't want to talk about it, so I still don't know much about the war. Everything is so vague, and it's hard to ask my mom questions about it. How can I bring it up without bringing up bad memories?" Family secrets such as these make visible the ways that war and migration "create ruptures in the family narrative that can never be wholly contained by an artificial peace in the refugee home."[36]

The hard-won peace in the refugee home is just that: a fragile truce that is fraught with lingering suspicion and unresolved hurts and that threatens to unravel at the slightest provocation. In Nhi Lý's family, her mother still has not forgiven her husband—Nhi's father—for his failure to escape with the family in 1983, as planned. Ethnically Chinese, Nhi's mother was part of the exodus of hundreds of thousands of Chinese Vietnamese who left Vietnam by boat in the early 1980s in response to the Vietnamese government's attempt to reduce their economic influence and to force their integration into the new nation. Amid the chaos of their escape, Nhi's father ended up staying behind, leaving his wife, who was pregnant with Nhi at the time, and two younger siblings, to fend for themselves. After drifting at sea for several days, their boat was picked up by a Hong Kong Navy ship. Nhi's mother then spent a year at a Hong Kong refugee camp, where Nhi was born, and then another six months at the Philippine Refugee Processing Center in Bataan before settling in Westminster, California. It would take another ten years before the father finally rejoined the family. In the intervening years, her mother's resentment had grown, hardened by the harshness of life as a single mother in a foreign country, and then fueled by the news that her husband's mother had asked permission for him to remarry while the couple was apart:

> My dad's mother asked my mom's mother for her permission and my mom got really pissed off cuz she was here by herself and she was supporting everybody, and she never dated. . . . When she and my dad fight, she would get snappy with my dad, she'd say something like, "I wonder why you didn't get on the boat?" Something like that, and my dad *never* answers. And like now when my dad wants to visit his mom [in Vietnam], my mom would say stuff like, "You want to go back because you want to visit the other family you have when I wasn't there!"

These stories of "personal transgressions"—and the silence that shrouds them—are instructive in another way: they remind us that even amid the horrors of war, people continue to *live* their lives, with warts and all. In these stories, we see men and women engaging in the age-old act of initiating and dodging relationships; in some ways, war seemed to have prodded them to risk more, such as when women upended sexual mores and became involved with married men, or when married men took advantage of chaotic times to shirk family

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

obligations. These very human (in)actions make a larger point: that war experiences are not only tragic or spectacular but also mundane and familiar. Trung Pha.m underscores this point—the ordinariness of life during wartime—when he recounts his parents' day-to-day life in Saigon during the early 1970s:

> My dad would still go to cafes and get coffee even though there was a threat of getting bombed or having some sort of sniper attack and the other things that happen in war. Even though there were threats, he was able to continue on with his daily life like teaching. Both my parents got their degrees in school during the war, and began to work as teachers during the war. Then they got married after the war. So even though it was a devastating event that occurred, and there were a lot of repercussions and all the deaths and destruction all around, there were still things that went on and continued to go on. I don't think that that's told enough because it's not as interesting to people.

While it is true that "things [go] on and continue to go on" even in the midst of war, it is also important to note that Trung's parents lived in cosmopolitan Saigon, which remained mostly calm and stable during the war—a reminder of the range of war experiences sustained by Vietnamese of different regions and socioeconomic classes across the country.

These stories about "personal transgressions" and everyday-ness of wartime remind us that, even in the midst of war, people are always more than victims of their circumstances; they are also desiring subjects with both simple and complex needs and wants. Our task as scholars is to figure out how to "communicate the depth, density, and intricacies of the dialectic of subjection and subjectivity."[37] We do this not only for the sake of accuracy but also out of respect for people's multifaceted and often-contradictory humanity and subjectivity.

PRIVATE GRIEF AND PUBLIC ACHIEVEMENTS

The media often hold up Vietnamese as an example of the quintessential American immigrant success story, but the socioeconomic conditions in which most Vietnamese children found themselves were greatly insecure, "comparable only to those encountered by children of the most underprivileged native minority group."[38] In 1990, the poverty rate of Vietnamese in the United States stood at 25 percent, down from 28 percent in 1980 but still substantially higher than the national average of 12 percent.[39] According to the 2010 U.S. Census, Vietnamese families living below the poverty line had dipped to 12 percent but were still higher than the national average of 10 percent.[40] Reflecting this economic trend, the majority of my respondents reported that they grew up in economically struggling households: 91 percent of the respondents' parents held nonprofessional jobs such as gardener, custodian, construction worker, and manual laborer for men, and manicurist, seamstress, housecleaner, and child or elderly caretaker for women. A number of respondents reported that their parents did "random" or "odd" jobs or that they were "jacks of all trades." Several unemployed fathers stayed home and took care of their children while their wives worked. Nonetheless, at the time of the interviews, 95 percent of the respondents were in college or had earned a college degree. As discussed in chapter 4, the media and social scientists fuel the "good refugee" narrative by singling out the academic and professional accomplishments of (some) Vietnamese refugees' children, citing them as evidence of cultural assimilation and economic integration. Below, I show that these attempts at prosperity are often valiant (if not always successful) efforts to manage and compensate for the personal and material losses incurred by their families during and after the war.

For the majority of the interviewees, economic insecurities haunt their home life. In chapter 4, I showed that American newspapers tend to overstate Vietnamese economic successes in the United States, bolstered by a "before" (shot) of the refugees languishing in backward and impoverished Vietnam, and an "after" (shot) of them flourishing in cosmopolitan and affluent United States. The young Vietnamese Americans in my study also offered "before" and "after" family stories, but they often flipped the script, depicting migration to the United States, the "after," as a move toward economic instability, replete with unstable, minimum-wage employment, lack of health insurance, and welfare dependency. The downward spiral was especially bitter

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

for formerly well-to-do refugees and their families. Liên Ngô, who came to the United States in 1982 at the age of ten, stated that her childhood ended abruptly when she witnessed her father's humiliating downward mobility:

> My dad, he was really wealthy in Vietnam, and he supported all of his thirteen brothers and sisters. Well, when he came over here and got a mechanic job, the mechanics discriminated against him. They thought that he didn't know anything so they gave him the janitor's job of cleaning the shop. My mom told me that . . . when she saw him cleaning the mechanics shop, she just started crying in the car. So that made me cry too. He was the boss and now he came over to America and he's a janitor.

Growing up, many of my respondents were hyper-aware of and anxious about their dire economic circumstances. Take Lan Hoàng's case, for example. Since coming to the United States as a boat refugee in 1983, Lan's monolingual father toiled as a janitor for a hotel, a school, and a supermarket; he also had a second job delivering pizza. Their chronic poverty crushed her father's spirit: "When my dad gets really drunk, he gets so emotional and he starts talking about his life, about what he accomplished and not accomplished, coming to America. Mostly what we hear is that he feels like he works so hard but he gets nowhere. He compares us to other people like people who have houses and everything and we don't have anything and we live paycheck by paycheck." Lan's mother contributed to the family's meager income by working as an electronic assembler, even when working with a microscope made her physically sick: "It can make you nauseous. And so she'd like throw up and she'd come home and tell my dad. And my dad just said, 'Well, you can't throw up all the time because if you keep doing that they won't let you work there.'" Because Lan's mother did not have a full-time position, she received no employer-provided health insurance. Lan described the anxiety of life without health insurance:

> I think my dad has health insurance but he doesn't buy it for my mom because it costs too much. My dad just said, "Just make sure you take care of yourself. When it's cold, make sure you're warm." My dad is like, "You just can't get sick." So one time my mom had stomach pain or something, I'm not sure what, she was crying and then she ended up crawling and stuff, and my dad didn't know what to do, so he had me call his insurance, Kaiser, and set up an appointment for him, but really it was for my mom. So then my mom went with him, and when they called my dad's name, he said, "No, it's for my wife." They were all like, "Are you okay? Is there something wrong?" My mom was like, "No, I'm not ok." After that, we got billed like a lot, like a thousand something, for running tests. . . . So I just didn't want to bring more troubles [for my parents], so I just watched TV and try to learn English from there. I didn't like to complain to them about not having things because there was no point. We were just poor.

It is true that downward mobility and economic insecurity is an immigrant story, not a refugee-specific one. However, our interviewees invariably traced their family's economic hardship back to war-related events, not to migration. For Erin Dương, learning about the war helped her to understand her parents better:

> I think early on I recognized that my stories, my family, my culture are different. How much so, how abnormal or how unnatural these things were, I didn't really fully grasp until I was much more mature. Probably not until I got to college and then I started to fully understand that this doesn't happen to everyone. I mean my family, they were refugees and they came from a country that was ravaged by war and their lives were endangered. There were broken families and my dad was born in 1950 and the country was at war in 1954 and then until 1975. So all of his life basically, there was war and that he had to grow up in. So it wasn't until I started to understand the context of what my family came from and when they were raised, that I began to understand their perspective and why they came here. And why they are so harsh on me and wanting me to excel and take advantage of the opportunities that I have. So it's a long process of understanding.

The war appeared to have affected men and women differently, saddling the latter with family responsibilities that at times required them to stay behind in Vietnam for years. Lisa Hồ's mother, as the oldest daughter, had to remain in Vietnam to take care of her ailing mother while the rest of the family left in 1975; she did not join them until 1993—eighteen years later. In another case, the oldest daughter had to manage all of the fallout from the war:

> My aunt was the oldest girl who didn't have a family yet, so she still had to take care of her brothers and sisters. Her

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

> oldest brother was in the military, and the other two sisters had families already, so they moved out. Once, their house was raided and all of their important papers were taken. Like papers for the house and the cars were taken. My aunt was the one who had to deal with it. My grandpa gave her those responsibilities. She also had to make sure that all of her younger brothers and sisters were safe. When my dad and my uncles were in the military, she had to go to this place to ask if they were still alive and if they were okay. I guess that was a lot of pressure and she felt like she was always in charge.

As a consequence, even when life was at its harshest in the United States, this aunt still refused to visit Vietnam because "she didn't want to return to a place where so much of her life and her youth was gone and taken from her."

Having witnessed their parents' economic anxiety and experienced its tolls on all of their lives, many interviewees felt deeply and personally responsible for realizing their parents' dream of "making it" in the United States. Their sense of responsibility was palpable: it had cost their parents too much to get here; it was their responsibility to fulfill their parents' dream of family success via intergenerational mobility. Below are some examples of this sentiment:

> I compare my life to what my parents had to go through. It's amazing, what they had to go through and the life that they built, from nothing to everything that they have given us. I don't think a lot of people my age have to think about that stuff. They don't think about what their parents did and how hard they worked. That's part of the reason why I try to work hard to make my parents proud. It's because I think about all they've given me. Just to make them happy everyday for them to look at their children and know that *they* made a difference.
>
> twenty-year-old Ngiệp Ngô

> When the Communists came, there were no opportunities. There was nothing for my dad to do. When he talks about how he grew up, there is a certain mentality that he has which is that there is a whole generation of young men like him whose futures were just wasted. He lived almost twenty years under Communist rule, and no one could be an intellectual. There was just no room for that, and I think that he really regretted it. It was a waste. My dad came here in his late forties and he had to catch up with the rest. And he'd had a really hard time. So he kept telling me and my brother that you need to go to school, graduate, work, and have a great life. I feel that they came here for our future and so now it's up to us to make it happen.
>
> twenty-two-year-old Thảo Hồ

> I think that the only reason why I intended to be pre-med was because of my parents and what they went through. I thought that this was the only way that I would be able to repay them.
>
> twenty-one-year-old Hiền Dương

In recent years, scholars have begun to explore how marginalized groups, and not only elites, use money and consumption to raise or secure their social standing. As Alex Kotlowitz reports, it is primarily as consumers—as "purchasers of the talisman of success"—that poor black youth claim social membership to the larger U.S. society.[41] In her insightful study of children of Asian immigrant entrepreneurs, Lisa Sun-Hee Park likewise shows that it is through conspicuous consumption that young Asian Americans attempt to claim their, and by extension their parents', social citizenship or belonging as Americans.[42] In other words, college and career choices are less, or not only, a sign of Vietnamese assimilation and social acceptance and more a sign of a complex and strategic response to their and their parents' forcible and "differential inclusion" into U. S. society. Having grown up in dire poverty, young Vietnamese Americans like Lan Hoàng knew that they needed to make money: "I was like who says money is not everything? Money is everything, you know. If you get sick and need to go to the doctor, how do you go to the doctor? Money, you know. The food you eat and the clothes you wear, you need money. And so if someone says money isn't everything, they're wrong. *Money is everything.*" For the majority of the young people whom I interviewed, their investment in success and money is meant to improve the lot and status of their families; it is not only or primarily about the pursuit of personal achievements. This investment in intergenerational economic mobility is much more than a reflection of "Vietnamese core cultural values": their alleged strong work ethic, high regard for education, and family values.[43] Rather, it exhibits the poignant and complex ways in which Vietnamese refugees and

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

their children use public achievements to address the lingering costs of war, to manage intimacy, to negotiate family tensions, and to ensure their social position and dignity in the racially and economically stratified United States.

No matter their resolve, living for their parents—for their dreams—exacts a high personal cost. For some, such as Lan Hoàng, the cost came in the form of a stunted childhood:

> I had to translate not just for my family but for my grandma. Everything that's sent to them, and then I got so stressed and sometimes I hated it. I was like eleven years old and I had to translate things like letters and papers and fill out forms and I didn't know anything . . . [starts to cry]. But it seems that they will never be satisfied, ok? Everything I do is like their standards and expectations are set way too high I guess . . . [sniffle] . . . and I feel like . . . I'm still bitter towards my parents even now because I think when I was a kid, you know, I shouldn't be doing that stuff like I should be having fun.

Some interviewees related that their childhood years were spent working alongside their parents to help improve the family's economic situation:

> I helped out my mom with the sewing jobs. I've done that ever since we came when I was in fourth grade up until high school. So yeah, I remember a lot of things, like how we would stay up until five or six in the morning to make the deadline. Probably one of the reasons why she did that is so that she can stay home and take care of the family. With the sewing job, she can do it anytime. It's funny because whenever I go to sleep, I would hear the machine and the noise. So when we quit, which was pretty recent since it was only a few years ago, I still keep on hearing the noise. I would still hear it, until I left for college and I was away from the machine. That's when I stopped hearing it.

For many others, their financial obligation to their parents influenced their job and other economic decisions. As Vân Nguyễn recounted:

> My brother and sister worked as young as they could when they were fourteen. So did I. We did different jobs like work in the supermarkets and at flea markets. My brother is the oldest and when he came [to the United States], he was fifteen. He had a hard time adjusting. He went to a community college. He's very smart, but he somehow felt isolated. So he joined the U.S. Navy when he was nineteen. . . . My sister stayed and went to a state university and graduated with a business degree. With this business degree, she works enough to make money to support my parents. We recently bought a house which was split evenly between my brother and my sister. My brother is paying more just because he's in the military and he has more of the federal income. . . . My brother recently tried to get out of the military because your contact ends every four years and you renew it every four years. So we are all trying to get him to leave, but he feels an obligation. He said that if he comes back now, then how will he find a stable income to pay the mortgage. So he feels a deep financial obligation. We told him that we will work together as a family and figure something out. Financially, it is always a family decision. We don't really think about who that house will go to or whose name that house will go under. It's a family house and we will do whatever to support it.

The pressure to contribute to the family economic well-being has, at times, led to unwise and desperate undertakings such as gambling. As Hiếu Trường related:

> My parents had random jobs. They didn't speak English. My mom sewed clothes for a couple of years. My dad helped her and then did other random jobs including being a gardener, working at McDonalds, and being a home caretaker. Then my older brother was really smart so he was taking classes, but then he realized that the family needed more money. He was in college at that time, so he just said that he would take a year off to make some money and then he would go back to school. But he didn't. He went into gambling mode, but I think it was out of good motivation. He really wanted to help out the family. My other brother went into gambling mode too, so it was really bad. The stress just affected us in all different ways. All of us have good intentions to help out the family. But we were all helpless in a way. My brothers didn't know what else to do. They know that they had to get a good education, but at the same time they wanted to help out the family. They felt trapped so they went into that gambling mode.

An irony in refugee life—indeed, in immigrant life generally—is that the steep sacrifices intended to achieve mobility for the family can end up tearing the family apart. In the following excerpt, Loan Dương recounted how her family grew apart as family members scrambled "just to survive" in the United States:

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

> When we came here, we understood that there were lots of opportunities here, but at the same time, we were lost. You know how Vietnamese people are: We are very family oriented. Our family in Vietnam was really strong. We're huge, yet when we came here, we were the only family here. There was no one else. In a way we felt really stranded and lost. We didn't know how to drive, we didn't know a lot of the stores around us, we didn't know how to eat a hamburger, and other little things. But those little things do add up. It makes you stress when you try to adapt. I think that stress permeated into our family and in a way disrupted it. In Vietnam, we were okay. But I think the stress from such a big transition divided us for a year or two. Some of us thought that maybe this was a wrong decision and we should have stayed in Vietnam. This place is horrible since we go to work eight hours a day and then go back. We hardly see each other since we work so much just to survive. For our family, meal times are important. We eat breakfast, lunch, and dinner together. All of our meals are together. Here, we had to eat separately because we all had to work. We felt strange since we thought that mealtime was really important. That was a big transition.

In this section, I have offered an alternative explanation for the postwar generation's seeming drive to succeed: what appears to be an act of economic assimilation on the part of the "generation after"—an act of moving beyond the war—is in actuality an index of the ongoing costs of war, not only for the witnesses and survivors but also for their children. When asked what Americans should know about the Vietnam War, many respondents offered this answer: that the war did not end in 1975. As Hiếu Trường exclaimed: "For my family, [the war] never really ended. People said it ended, but it still went on even after the takeover." Many interviewees insisted that Americans should pay attention to "not only what happened during the war but also what happened after the war" and "to know about the people and what happened to them when they came here." In the end, for these young Vietnamese Americans, when they consider the Vietnam War, they think most about what happened to their families after they came to the United States. This is the part of the war that they knew most intimately and shared most freely. Their insistence that we pay heed to family life is an important reminder that wars affect not only the realms of politics and economics but also "people's intimate social ecologies."[44] As such, the domains of the intimate—in this case, Vietnamese family life—constitute a key site to register the lingering costs of war that often have been designated as over and done with in the public realm.

"THE GANGSTER WE ARE ALL LOOKING FOR": ABOUT INTERGENERATIONAL TENSIONS AND SHARED LIVES

Most popular and scholarly writings on immigrant and refugee families tend to naturalize intergenerational tension, attributing it to the "culture clash" between "traditional" immigrant parents and their more Americanized children.[45] My discussion thus far suggests that intergenerational strain, even when it is seemingly unrelated to war, is not a private matter between refugee parents and their children but a social, historical, and geopolitical affair that exposes multiple and interrelated forms of power relations. In this section, I turn to lê thi diem thúy's 2003 novel, *The Gangster We Are All Looking For,* for a critical rendering of family dynamics within refugee families. As Lisa Lowe has argued, "Culture is a . . . mediation of history, the site through which the past returns and is remembered, however fragmented, imperfect, or disavowed."[46] This critical remembering is key to the formation of oppositional narratives and "to the imagination and rearticulation of new forms of political subjectivity, collectivity, and practice."[47] In recent years, Vietnamese American artists such as lê have begun to grapple with the war's disastrous consequences for Vietnam and its people, giving rise to often-haunting artistic and cultural representations that imagine, remember, and trace the complex genealogies of war and forced displacements that precede and shape Vietnamese resettlement in the United States. As such, I am interested in Vietnamese American cultural forms for what they can reveal and expand on the tensions, irresolutions, and contradictions of Vietnamese American lives.

Told through the knowing eyes of a lonely and imaginative child, *The Gangster* is a quietly powerful account of a Vietnamese refugee family who is in America but not of it.[48] Part memoir, part novel, it is among the first book-length fictional works to come from the "boat people" generation of the late 1970s and early 1980s. In 1978, six-year-old lê and her father fled their home village of Phan Thiết in southern Vietnam in a small fishing boat, leaving behind her mother and younger siblings. After a brief stay in a refugee camp

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

in Singapore, they were resettled in Linda Vista, a racially diverse working-class community in San Diego. In 1980, lê's mother and younger sister, after a stint in a refugee camp in Malaysia, joined them in San Diego.[49] Like many of my interviewees, growing up, lê sensed an implicit silence in her family about the Vietnam War: "When my dad got together with his friends, they would sing songs and tell stories about when they were schoolboys. But there was a way they leapt over the war and the aftermath of the war. There was no one for me to turn to with my questions: how did we get here? Why are we boat people? If my mom misses her parents, and our town, then why aren't we there? And because I had no one to ask those questions, I swallowed them inside myself."[50] At the same time, she was bombarded with media images of the Vietnam War as a spectacle—and as an American tragedy: "In mainstream narrative about Vietnam, it's usually about the American GI, while the Vietnamese are part of the landscape. They rarely get particularized as characters."[51] lê wrote *The Gangster* in part to put on record what happened to the Vietnamese people, not just during the war, but also before and after the war: "In this country . . . [t]he questions about what happened to Vietnamese people don't get brought up. . . . For America to grow in its consciousness, it needs to ask what happened to the Vietnamese."[52]

In lyrical prose that reads like poetry, lê depicts the United States not as the land of opportunities but as the breaker of families—a place where family life will never be what it could or should have been. Haunting the narrator's family is the specter of her dead older brother, who drowned in Vietnam when he was just six years old—a death made more tragic by the absence of the father who was being held in a reeducation camp. The brother's death provides lê with a narrative device to move the story back and forth between Vietnam and California and to shift time, place, and viewpoint constantly throughout the novel. As lê interweaves memories of Vietnam with incidents in the United States, she melds the past and present, conveying the fluidity of time but also the unending-ness of the war's impact on Vietnamese lives. As she reminds us: "War has no beginning and no end. It crosses oceans like a splintered boat filled with people singing a sad song."[53] Unlike other immigrant accounts, lê's novel depicts the family's arrival in the United States not as the end but as the beginning of the story, poignantly detailing the main characters' struggles with living a life not of their own design. The young narrator bemoans her parents' unfulfilled dreams and unfulfilling lives in America: "[Ma] worked as a seamstress, doing piecework at our kitchen table. [Ba] worked as a welder at a factory that made space heaters. Neither of them wanted to be doing it; Ma wanted to have a restaurant, and Ba wanted to have a garden."[54] She *sees* their poverty intensely, in the rusted gates of their small red apartment building, in her father's hopeless rage, and in her parents' "big fight[s] about nothing" and in the "awful quiet" that ensues.[55]

Most poignant are the exquisite portraits of the haunted, brooding father "who cries in the garden every night"[56] and who is "sad and broken."[57] His loneliness, sadness, and brokenness—the result of years of devastating war, punishing reeducation camp, demeaning jobs, and crushing poverty—often turn into hopeless rage: "He becomes prone to rages. He smashes televisions, VCRs, chases friends and family down the street, brandishing hammers and knives in broad daylight."[58] At night, once his rage has subsided, he sits motionless in the dark for hours, "his body absolutely still, his hands folded on his lap, penitent . . . straining toward things no one can see."[59] Mindful of the father's inner turmoil, the daughter's memories of him and their relationship contain a mixture of tender and terrifying moments:

> To protect myself, I tried to forget everything: that first night at the refugee camp in Singapore; those early morning walks after we arrived in America; the sound of his voice asking a question no one could answer; the shapes his fists left along a wall; the bruises that blossomed on the people around him; the smell of the fruit he brought home from the gardens he tended; the way the air seemed charged with memories of blood; the nets we fell through, faster and faster, year after year, dreaming of land.[60]

In the following scene, which takes place in a runaway shelter, lê beautifully depicts the complexity of the father-daughter relationship, one that refuses to be privatized but calls into being the larger history and context of war, refugee resettlement, and chronic poverty:

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

> Before I had run away for good, my father once came to pick me up at a shelter. As we sat in a conference with two counselors, he was asked if there was anything he wanted to say. He shook his head. When pressed, he looked down at his hands. He apologized for what his hands had done. The counselors understood this to mean he was taking responsibility for his drunken rages. They nodded in approval. But then he drew his palms together and apologized for all that his hands had not been able to do. He spread his hands wide open, and said, in Vietnamese, to anyone who could understand, there were things he had lost grasp of.
>
> The room seemed to shrink in the face of his sorrow. Beside him the two counselors were like tight little shrubs no one had ever watered. I thought they had no right to frown at my father. I could not wait to get us out of there. I told the counselors that I was ready to go home. I remember crossing the parking lot, my hand in my father's hand, the two of us running to the car as though we were escaping together again.[61]

In this excerpt, lê denaturalizes domestic violence among poor refugee families by showing how it is intimately linked to the violence of war, of urban neglect, and of poverty. In so doing, she disrupts the widespread construction of patriarchy as particular to Asian culture, which freezes Asian immigrant men as always-already "subjects who perpetrate violence," and foregrounds the need to theorize and situate all forms of male violence.[62] Stressing the intersection of race, gender, and class, she makes clear how gender differentiation and oppression is not a universal experience but is structured differently, depending on how it intersects with other inequalities such as race and class. Thus, from their race and class vantage point, the two social service workers understand the gesture of the father as an apology for domestic violence—"for what his hands had done." In contrast, the marginalized father and daughter recognize that the apology is more for what "his hands had *not* been able to do." More than a cultural misunderstanding, the scene evinces a power struggle in which the feminist values of the American counselors are deemed universal while those of the powerless refugees are misrecognized—though not entirely silenced. The novel thus exhorts us to acknowledge that economic and social discrimination have locked many working-class men of color into an unequal relationship with not only privileged white men but also privileged white women.[63]

Facing the overbearing and patronizing social service workers, the daughter abruptly and protectively took her father's hand and both fled—away from the oppressive state system that threatened to further humiliate a man who has just apologized for what "his hands had not been able to do." This scene encapsulates the parent-child role reversal common in immigrant families: the night they left Vietnam, it was the father who carried the daughter down to the beach and placed her on the fishing boat; but now in America, it was the English-speaking daughter who freed the father from the prying bureaucrats in the shelter. This act—"of escaping together again"—moves the story beyond the familiar trope of intergenerational conflict to one about joint lives. Although the daughter and father are divided by generation, culture, and language, they are connected by their shared histories. The crises that have shaped the father—war trauma, reeducation camps, boat escape, and chronic underemployment in the United States—while unknown to and unheard by the social service workers, are deeply felt and lived by the daughter who has witnessed and braved many of these hardships alongside her father. It is this witnessing that enables the daughter to *see* her father as one who is never utterly defeated: "His friends fell all around him . . . first during the war and then after the war, but somehow he alone managed to crawl here, on his hands and knees, to this life."[64] Avery Gordon has explained that a structure of feeling articulates "the tangled exchange of noisy silences and seething absences."[65] Therein lies the contribution of lê's novel: it makes audible and visible the "noisy silences" and "seething absences" in Vietnamese life, exposing the material, cultural, and political circumstances that constrain the refugees' everyday lives, their responses to and against these constraints, and the emotional tensions that result.

• • • • •

The focus of this chapter has been on "postmemory": how young Vietnamese Americans, born and/or raised in the United States, have created their own memories of a war that took place before they were born. I have traced the repercussions of the Vietnam War, which extended far beyond the official end of the war in April 1975, into the postwar generation, not in the visible tragedies that occur in the public realm but in the

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.

Copyright © 2014. University of California Press. All rights reserved.

hidden injuries that play out in the "domains of the intimate."[66] Focusing on family silences and secrets, I have shown that refugee families often adopt what Park calls a "don't ask, don't tell" strategy, as children implicitly know not to ask their parents about potentially painful topics about their background and migration history; instead, they string together bits and pieces of their own memories and overheard stories to create a bearable and repeatable version of their family's war and refugee experiences—one that emphasizes academic and economic gains, which invariably, though not always intentionally, validates the myth of the United States as the land of opportunity.[67] For the postwar generation, then, the war has become a shifting specter that explains or explains away past transgressions, family tensions, and/or economic instabilities, and it is a constant motivator that pushes them to assuage private grief with public achievements. The postwar generation's practice of looking to their present conditions in order to understand their parents' past corroborates one of the strongest and most enduring premises of Walter Benjamin's conception of history: the belief that it is not history that enables us to understand the present but, conversely, the present that enables us to understand the past.[68] This conception of history suggests that there is no way to close off new understandings of the Vietnam War, even for the postwar generation(s), and that it is precisely through the domains of the everyday that people remember, forge, and transform a past that has been long suppressed.

Espiritu, Yen Le. Body Counts : The Vietnam War and Militarized Refugees, University of California Press, 2014. ProQuest Ebook Central, http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/uci/detail.action?docID=1711008.
Created from uci on 2025-12-31 00:10:52.